

Just for the sport
The maharaja of Mysore's men carry away a tiger killed in a shikar, circa 1950

GETTY IMAGES

INDIA IS HOME TO

7.6% of the world's mammal species

14.7% of its amphibian species

6% of birds

6.2% of reptiles

(Species of the world. Source: UNEP)



The Asiatic Cheetah is the only large predator to have gone extinct in India in the past 75 years

40,000
Estimated number of tigers in India in 1947

2,967
Tigers as per latest census

9
Tiger reserves initially created during 1973-'74

53
Tiger reserves in India

106
National parks in India

FEARNING OUR STRIPES

Much of our wildlife was once treated as big game. The turning point came 50 years ago. With the creation of many national parks, wildlife protection is now a principle India lives by

By ***Rahul Noronha***

Few causes have been championed as steadfastly in the past 50 years in India as wildlife conservation. The country's sheer variety of species in the wild overshadows even Africa—that paradise of wildlife in the eyes of enthusiasts. At the time of independence, the general public was largely wary of wildlife, which was also seen as something that entertained the elite. Predators were feared by communities that came in contact with them. Princes who ruled over roughly a third of India before independence protected them though, ironically, only for indulging in the time-honoured tradition of the *shikar*. For nearly three decades after independence, wildlife continued to be harvested for sport by the rich and for meat by communities